EZETIMIBE

Add-on to statins

Once daily

CHEMICAL NAME (3R,4S)-1-(4-fluorophenyl)-3-[(3S)-3-(4-fluorophenyl)-3-hydroxypropyl]-4-(4-hydroxyphenyl)azetidin-2-one

CLASS Cholesterol absorption inhibitor

TRADE NAMES Ezetrol · Zetia · Inegy / Vytorin (with simvastatin) · Atozet (with atorvastatin)

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Hypercholesterolaemia — add-on to statin when LDL target not reached.
- Statin intolerance (monotherapy).
- Homozygous familial hypercholesterolaemia; sitosterolaemia.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** once daily at any time, with or without food.
- Separate from bile-acid sequestrants (2 h before or 4 h after).

DOSAGES

- **Adult & child ≥6 yr:** 10 mg once daily.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Peak:** 1–2 h (glucuronide 4–12 h).
- Glucuronidated in intestine and liver to active metabolite; enterohepatic recirculation.
- Excreted in faeces. **t½:** 22 h.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Monitor lipid profile at 4–12 weeks.
- LFTs when used with statins.
- Ask about muscle symptoms.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Inhibits **NPC1L1** transporter in small-intestine brush border → ↓ cholesterol absorption (dietary and biliary).
- ↓ LDL-C by ~20% alone; additional ~25% when added to statin.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Diarrhoea, abdominal pain.
- Fatigue, headache.
- Myalgia (with statin).

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Raised liver enzymes (with statin).
- Myopathy (rare).
- Hypersensitivity, pancreatitis (rare).

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Hypersensitivity.
- With a statin: active liver disease, pregnancy, breastfeeding.
- **Caution:** moderate–severe hepatic impairment.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Ciclosporin:** ↑ levels of both.
- **Fibrates:** ↑ gallstone risk.
- **Cholestyramine:** ↓ absorption.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Take once daily with your statin.
- Keep up diet and exercise.
- Report muscle pain or yellow skin.

KEY POINTS

- Blocks intestinal cholesterol absorption (NPC1L1).
- Add-on to statin (~25% further LDL fall).
- 10 mg once daily.
- Well tolerated.

SOURCES CHECKED **[401]** Ezetimibe 10 mg tablets (UK SmPC) **[402]** Ezetimibe, oral (US label) **[403]** Ezetimibe, oral (US label, A-S Medication Solutions)

Full references p. 432–457